# Who Are We?

## By Alan Kaufman

## INTRODUCTION

*Growing up in the Bronx with a deeply depressed mother who was a Holocaust survivor, Alan Kaufman came to grips with his Jewish heritage in disquieting ways: he found himself facinated by photos of German death camps, formed a clique in high school that jokingly called for "death to the Jews" and created "The Purple Jew," a comic book that featured a Jewish superhero even as Kaufman understood that "more than anything in the world, I wanted not to be Jewish." Who Are We? By Alan Kaufman*

Into the past
I go like a stranger
to discover why at night
I lay alone as a child
waiting for the front door
to slam, my father gone
to night-shift work,
and my mother, Marie, to enter, unable to sleep, and tell
me

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tales of childhood
war, pursued by those
who, as she spoke,
seemed to enter the room, Gestapo men in leather coats
who ordered me to pack
and descend to a waiting truck,

for I am still going to Auschwitz though a grown man in
1999
I am still boarding the freight, crushed against numbed,
frightened Jews and Gypsies and Russian soldiers and
homosexuals
crossing frontiers to be gassed

I am her, in my heart,
though I am six feet two
and two hundred and ten pounds and have played college
football and served as a soldier
and have scars from fights
with knives and jagged
bottles smashed on bars

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I am still her, little girl, hiding in chicken coops
and forests, asleep on dynamite among partisans
I am still her, brushing teeth with ashes
from the ruins of nations gutted in war
I am still her brown eyes and black hair of persecution
foraging scraps of thistle soup, a star-shaped patch
sewn to my shirt

I am still my mother
every day in the streets
of New York or San Francisco, the chimney skies glow
and swirl with soot like night above
a crematorium, or the Bronx incinerator chute where I
threw out trash in a brick darkness shooting sparks

I am still her in the streets of Berkeley, walking among

sparechangers, dyed-hair punkers, gays in stud leather,
Blacks, Mexicans and Asians

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I am still her rounded up among poets and thieves
and politically incorrect
social deviants
on sun-drenched sidewalks
in the Mission and the Haight, Greenwich Village, the
Lower East Side, or anywhere the weird
congregate in tolerance

And every day in this age
of intolerance,
in a mental ghetto
affirmed by the homeless,
I pass the dying
with the loud ring of my boots, ashamed to think that
perhaps my heels are the last thing
they heard
Every day I am a
survivor of AIDS and poverty

Every day I sit in cafes watching tattoos turn to
numbers and I grow angry

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I want America back

I want America to be

the home I never had

And you, who are you if you hear my voice? Who are you,

stranger if you read these words?

Who are we

who stand threatened

in these times of darkness? Who are we, condemned to

die, who do not know ourselves

at all?

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Alan Kaufman***
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